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healthy kids

child

8TH ANNIVERSARY SPECIAL

INDIA

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we help you figure it out

smart strategies
to nurture
exceptional
children



achievers
and what
makes
them tick

COLIC 101
tips to
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learn to manage the
classroom challenges
of an autistic kid



back
to
school

45 COOL PRODUCTS
TO SNAG FOR THAT SCHOOL BAG



**choose
smart**
signs of a great
preschool
revealed

**CELEBRATE
EARTH DAY**
with 4 fun-filled
activity
sheets

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between you and us

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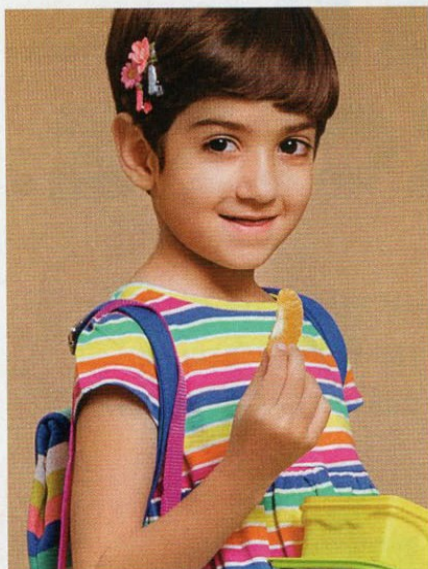
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ON THE COVER Shivene Sinha, 7 years; Photograph by Chandan Ahuja; Styled by Mahima Shukla; Produced by Ragini Singh and Ritika Jain.

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wonderful minds inspiring stories

On our 8th anniversary, we tell the tales of eight prodigies who will make you proud of being an Indian. by **SASWATI SARKAR**

Children born with extraordinary qualities have a very different trajectory from those who aren't. Fortunately or unfortunately, there is no parenting manual for either. So, it is likely that you err either by pushing your prodigy too much or by failing to spot or nurture his gift. We speak to parents of gifted kids who have successfully nourished the special talents of their little geniuses. Read up to know how they did it.



* painter par excellence

Shorya Mahanot, 9,
Neemuch (MP), Son of
Aditya and Pushpa

DUBBED as child Picasso by the media, Shorya discovered his penchant for painting when he was just 3 years old. "My older daughters, Shreya and Shruti, also love painting. One day, he took up their colours and canvas and made a painting on his own. It was beautiful. Initially, we thought it was a fluke but decided to encourage him to paint more. We got him a lot of canvasses and he didn't waste a single one," recalls his father, Aditya. This young abstract artist from the small town of Neemuch, MP, first hit the headlines when famous cartoonist RK Laxman took him under his wing at age 5. From then on, there was no looking back and his work started getting noticed and appreciated by art aficionados in India and abroad. "So far, Shorya has made around 200 paintings and 21 of them have already been sold. But all this success hasn't changed his persona. He is still the same little caring guy who adjusts with everybody in the family and tries to play the role of a mood booster if anyone feels low," says his mother, Pushpa.

Aditya wants his son to flourish in his hometown. "We want him to stay grounded and don't impose our dreams on him. We are okay if he wants to take up painting as a hobby, not a profession. But I will do whatever it takes to help him pursue his passion," he says. "I have chosen a school for him which will allow him enough time to cultivate his special talent," he adds.

➔ **secret to success** **Originality.** "We discovered a pattern in his paintings. It was surprising to see a child of his age creating a signature style and we don't want any external influence on his works. So we haven't appointed a trainer for him," says the proud father.

achievement to celebrate Shorya's work has received recognition in India and the world over. This child artist is among the famous few whose paintings have been displayed at art galleries like the Ward-Nasse and Holtzman galleries of the USA and Bougain Villaea Gallery in India. He also received the POGO Television Amazing Kid Award in 2012.



* prolific orator
Ishita Katyal, 10,
Pune, Daughter of Vikas
and Nancy

achievement to
celebrate **Being**
the youngest
Indian to speak at
the TEDYouth
Conference in New
York, 2015. She
also shared the
stage with NASA
engineers at the
TED Conference in
Vancouver, 2016.



AN ORIGINAL thinker with amazing conversational skills—that's what this wonder girl from Pune is. "From a very early age, Ishita Katyal started picking up new words at ease. Her teachers also gave us the feedback that for a young child, she articulates her thoughts a bit too well. At her age, she has a voice on numerous topics," says her mother, Nancy. Ishita also has an extraordinary ability to connect with people.

As parents, Vikas and Nancy have always given their daughter a free hand to choose her path. "We always appreciate anything new she wants to take up or any creative idea that pops up in her head. Even when she wanted to write a book, we had given her a go-ahead without any hesitation. While we encourage her to set high benchmarks for herself and try to make her believe that nothing is impossible, we also tell her to follow her passion," says the beaming mother.

While Ishita's parents have never pressurized her to take part in the marks race, her school has also been very supportive. "We believe in striking a balance between studies and creative thinking. This, I guess, paid off. She has developed new and unique ways to learn: She uses her aptitude for drawing to make pictures of the learning concepts," says Nancy.

➔ **secret to success** **Listening skills.** Ishita is a good listener. "She respects others' emotions. Whenever asked a question, she interprets it on the basis of the content and the emotions behind it and then responds," says Nancy.



* einstein in the making
Kautilya Pandit, 9,
Kohand (Haryana)

This wonder kid with an IQ of 150, same as that of Albert Einstein's, can memorize and talk about almost anything under the sun, be it the names of galaxies or the GDP of Indonesia. And all this, at 5 years of age. This 'mobile encyclopaedia' has the details of 213 countries, including their per capita income,

gross domestic product, politics, economy, etc. on his finger tips. According to his parents, Kautilya, often nicknamed as the Google Boy, spent his toddler years delving deep into the whats, whys and hows of everything around him. His parents' patience with his incessant questions seemed to have paid off.

HAILING from Israna, a village of sugarcane fields and wrestlers in Haryana, where nobody had heard the word 'golf' until now, Shubham Jaglan was introduced to this rich man's game by his grandfather. This happened when a US-based golfing enthusiast opened a coaching academy nearby. However, it shut down within a couple of months. "It was then that I got a call from the owner to meet him. He insisted that Shubham continues the game. When I asked why, his reply was, 'You will get to know, gradually.' Though golf isn't a game that somebody from our socio-economic stratum can pursue, I didn't want to dampen my son's spirit. I wanted to help him chase his dream. Twice a week, I used to take him to Madhuban Golf Course in Karnal, 40 kms away from our village, for practice," says Jagpal, Shubham's father.

Shubham didn't let his father's efforts go waste. He kept on performing well, winning local junior tournaments. His talent soon became the topic of discussion among the golfing elite, so much so that the Golf Foundation, run by former Asian Games gold medallist Amit Luthra, decided to fund his education in Delhi and practice at the Delhi Golf Club. So, the Jaglans moved to Delhi, selling off their dairy cattle.

"It was a huge decision for us but our son proved our move right. He makes me feel proud as a father, not by his sheer golfing skills, but also by the fact that he is so simple and sincere. He doesn't neglect his studies on the pretext of the game. His teachers are also very cooperative. They allot special classes for him," says the father, smiling.

Jagpal and his wife Anjana want their son to stay as grounded as he is now, even when he grows up to be a world famous golfer. "As parents, we are trying our level best to infuse the kind of culture and tradition in him that keeps him attached to his roots," says Anjana.

The grounded golfer nurtures his Olympic dreams with utter care as he makes sure that he doesn't slack on his efforts, be it his sport or studies.

➔ **secret to success** **Commitment.** "He is so devoted to his game that nothing can distract him or shift his focus from his passion," says Anjana.



***tycoon of the tees**

Shubham Jaglan, 11,
Delhi, Son of Jagpal
and Anjana

achievement to celebrate The blue-eyed boy of coach Nonita Lall Qureshi, Shubham won back-to-back titles in the US in 2015: The IJGA World Stars of Junior Golf and the Junior World Golf Championships. He had also won the Taylormade World Juniors in July 2013. Prior to these, Shubham had won junior tournaments in India as well.



✱ the beat master | **Truptraj Pandya, 9**, Mumbai,
Son of Atul and Veena

BORN with an innate sense of rhythm and a pair of dexterous hands, this little music maestro-in-the-making showed signs of his talent when he was just 18 months old. “As an infant, he used to play a toy *dholki* in perfect beats and rhythm. Also, while listening to his grandmother’s devotional songs, my son used to keep up the beat on aluminium *dabbas*,” says his father Atul.

The Pandyas have a culture of music at home. Atul himself has a knack for singing and had got a tabla as a gift. Once, when he was 2 years old, Truptraj woke up in the middle of the night and forced his mom to let him play it. An enthusiastic father as he was, Atul, made a video clip out of this and sent it to the Guinness Book of World Records. They acknowledged him as a 2-year-old tabla player. “I wanted the world to know about his extraordinary talent,” says the enthusiastic father.

While Atul won’t leave any stone unturned to channelize his son’s talent properly, he knows exactly what to do when Truptraj’s performance dips. “In one of the competitions, he didn’t do well and was very upset. I had told him that Sachin Tendulkar doesn’t score a century in every match. You should learn to accept success and failure alike. But at the same time, never lose sight of your goal. Be like Arjuna and see the bird’s eye,” he recalls.

➔ **secret to success** **Determination.** “When Truptraj was younger, he sometimes used to fall asleep before his performance. But when his turn would come, nothing would stop him from giving his best,” recalls Atul.

achievement to celebrate Truptraj made it to the Guinness Book of World Records as the world’s youngest tabla performer for playing live at the All India Radio at the age of 3. He had also received the Baal Kala Ratna Award at age 2.



✱ passionate
percussionist
Anshuman Nandi, 5,
Pratapgarh (Tripura)

Winning the national award for exceptional achievement in the field of music at the age of 3, this drummer from Tripura caught the attention of many in the field. Inspired by his father Biswajit, a professional drummer himself, Anshuman fell in love with drum sticks instead of toys and won a million hearts. He mastered the art by observing his father teach his students. He also appeared on TV shows like *India’s Got Talent* and *SA RE GA MA PA*.

BORN to a family of chess players, Pari grew up watching her father and uncle warring on the chess board. So she picked up the moves of chess much earlier than the alphabet. "We had decided to train her at home and Pari received her first lessons in chess from uncle Ved Prakash Sinha, a national level player," says her father, Jay Prakash.

This doting dad dreams to make his daughter a world champion some day. And why not? Even chess Grandmaster Praveen Thipsay could see immense potential in this little genius! "Like many other chess players of reckon, he had also visited us when he saw Pari playing. 'Some day, I would like to coach her,' was his reaction. This was encouragement enough for us," says the father, with twinkling hope in his eyes. Pari's mother also has faith in her daughter's abilities. "She is just a child now. But she succeeds in doing everything that she grasps. Pari doesn't need to be pushed. She has to be told just once," says Manju.

However, they know that raising a chess champion isn't an easy task and there will be roadblocks too. They are also not blind to the possibilities of a failure. But they are prepared for it all. "If chess doesn't click, she will take care of the family business. But I would always want her to stick to the game. It improves patience and boosts concentration, which are essential for her studies," says Jay Prakash.

➔ **secret to success** **Patience and determination.** "She never gives up, even in a pressure cooker situation," says her father. Also, this tiny chess sensation has high pick-up skills.



*** queen of 64 squares**

Pari Sinha, 6, Patna,
Daughter of Jay Prakash
and Manju

achievement to celebrate **At the age of 3, this girl made her debut at a state-level chess competition and ranked third in the under-7 category. She checkmated opponents twice her age.**



*** the pint-sized pianist**
Jacob Samuel, 12, Chennai

This music prodigy started playing piano at the age of 2. Drawing inspiration from his father, who used to play organ in the church, Jacob started reproducing the tunes based on the music that he was exposed to. Gradually, his musical talent expanded. Now the precocious pianist, who considers music as

God's gift to him, can reproduce Bach, Chopin and Beethoven and the likes. At 12, Jacob, the student of AR Rahman's KM Conservatory, Chennai, is headlining concerts by himself and wowing the audience of India, Dubai and New York with his perfect pitch, innate musicality and wonderful sense of drama. ●